

08a Divine Familial Terms 1 (DFT 1): Belief – Walkthrough

(White board; slide deck – 45 min.)

Intro: We are going to talk about a doctrinal belief that is named Divine Familial Terms. *(Familial is an academic term for family, Divine Familial Terms are the family terms used within the Godhead.)*

This is a mouthful (even for us English speakers). This doctrinal belief is about the terms *Father* and *Son* when used for God and Jesus. It is related to the doctrine of the Trinity—God is one and exists in three persons. This is important to talk about because the Bible uses different titles and names for each of the three persons of God.

The Scriptures use several names or titles for the persons of the Trinity.

Ask: What are some names or titles you can think of that the Bible uses for Jesus? *(Write their ideas on the board.)*

- Jesus Christ (John 1:17)
- Messiah (John 1:41; John 4:25)
- Son of Man (Matthew 9:6)
- Son of God (Matthew 14:33)

Ask: What are some names or titles you can think of that the Bible uses for God? *(Write their ideas on the board.)*

- Father (Matthew 5:16)
- Almighty (Genesis 17:1)
- Yahweh God (Genesis 2:4)

Ask: What are some names or titles you can think of that the Bible uses for the Holy Spirit?

(Write their ideas on the board.)

- Comforter/Helper/Advocate (John 14:16; John 16:7—differs by English version)
- Spirit of God (Matthew 3:16)
- Spirit of truth (John 16:13)

Ask: Do you think God intended to convey specific truths about who He is through the names He uses in the Scriptures?

We believe that since the Bible is God's Word, we should use the exact names He uses when talking about Himself. God defines Himself as Father and Jesus as His Son. And we do not have the right to change that.

Some people have translated these terms differently in order not to offend non-believers in their region. Instead of calling Jesus God's Son, they may call Him God's chosen one, or sent one, or beloved one. Instead of calling God Father, they may use Most High or Holy One.

Ask: What might be lost if the terms *Son* and *Father* are changed in these ways?

- The nature of the relationship between God and Jesus
 - The significance of God's Son being sacrificed on our behalf by His Father
 - The eternal nature of Jesus
 - The relationship of the Trinity
- **Example:** 1 John 4:14 – “The Father has sent the Son to be the Savior of the world.”
 - If “Son” is replaced with “beloved one” or some other term, it does not make it clear that the Savior is God, and it does not show how great God's sacrifice was.
 - **Ask: What difference would changing *Father* make in the verse below?**

John 5:17–18 (Jesus is speaking) – “My Father is working even now and I, too, am working.’ Because of this, the Jews sought even more to kill him because he not only broke the Sabbath, but also called God his own Father, making himself equal with God.”

- If the term “Father” is replaced with “My Lord” or “My Master,” then the idea that Jesus made Himself equal with God makes no sense. The rest of this verse is very confusing if He does not in fact call God “My Father.”

Other possible verses: John 10:30–31, 33, 36, Hebrews 1:8, John 3:16.

Confirm: The translation leaders understand what Divine Familial Terms are and the importance of translating them accurately.